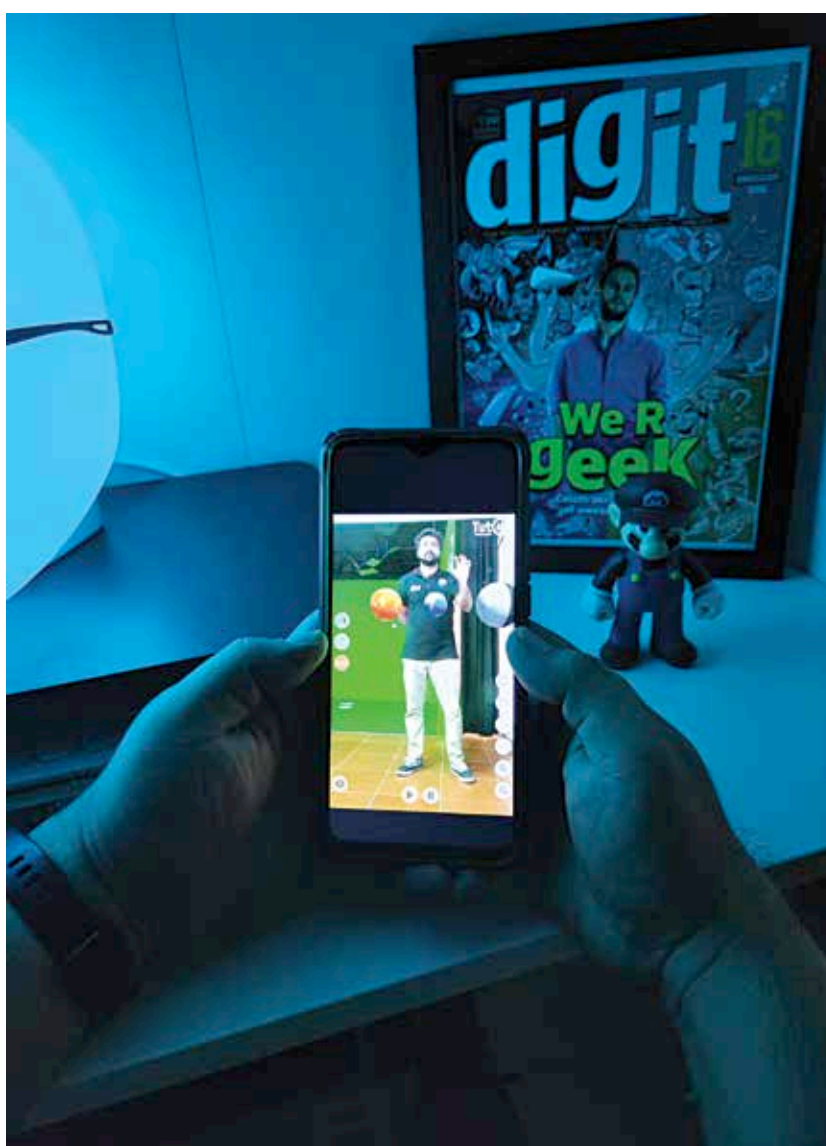


In his usual, time-tested strategy, forty-year-old Suvith, who heads sales and marketing at Infusory, was standing before teachers in Maharishi Vidya Mandir, a privately owned co-ed school in Chennai, when he asked the teachers how they utilise interactive panels installed in classrooms. He got the answer he was expecting: teachers played videos in the classroom, from either YouTube or ed-tech startups. In almost a practiced tone, he recalled telling them, “At the end of the day, these edtech companies and youtubers are teaching your students, and then, what is the point of you being a teacher in the classroom?”

Thomson Tom, founder and Chief Executive Officer at Infusory, agrees with this stance. “If you’re having a YouTube video, the only role the teacher is playing in class is to play and pause. That is not how education is supposed to be.” Shyam Pradeep Alil, Infusory’s co-founder and Chief Technology Officer, feels that the indiscriminate use of bland powerpoint presentations and borrowed videos in classrooms that started after the smartboard revolution in the 2010s led to school teachers losing their importance in education. “There is no student-teacher interaction if all a teacher does is play videos. It’s bad for students. They will not develop character.”

A year ago, Dr Meena, then a principal in Trivandrum’s Sree Gokulam Public School, was convinced by these arguments and started employing TutAR’s 3-D models in classroom learning. “To be frank, I was very happy with the results in classrooms, especially in the Science subjects,” she said. “For example, when a teacher is teaching about a heart, this 3-D model comes right in front of the students, and standing there, she can turn it around and poke it. I can actually show students a beating heart, pumping blood, and it is amazing.” As per the principal, after using augmented reality in classrooms, students have increasingly started



interacting with teachers and come up with a lot more questions.

“But that does not mean they don’t need to improve. Rather, they should improve,” she stressed. “They also need to develop interactive models for social sciences and languages. What they have right now is very limited.”

Thomson Tom, the twenty-seven-year-old CEO, wants TutAR to be a teacher’s tool. “We want to empower teachers. With these models, they can make classes a lot more interactive than relying on ready-made content. At the same time, it is the feedback of these teachers who use TutAR that helps us get better. We frequently update and add new models in our app based on teachers’ suggestions.”

THE MAKING OF TUTAR

The app TutAR was launched in 2020 after a few local schools came onboard with the idea of leveraging augmented reality in classrooms. When TutAR was just an idea – no app, no content – Suvith and co pitched the concept to Thrissur’s Nirmalamatha Central School. The administration came on board and asked them when they’d be able to provide the app. “Covid played a major role in enabling tech inside classrooms,” Thomson said. “Covid made teachers create online classes, made them video producers, made them so tech-savvy that now when we were pitching augmented reality to them, they actually were excited.”